

PRINCE ANAX

PART 1 & PART 2

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By Tom LaPille

Anax ran around the edge of the gymnasium. The scalding summer sun was getting high in the sky. He was sweating and his lungs burned, but it felt good.

He ran past the rack of spears and swords, past the stand of weighted practice shields, past the leather aprons and piles of stones. He ran past armored soldiers drilling shield walls, past men throwing weights in the sand pit.



Art by Steven Belledin

Once, he ran through the garden, for a few minutes of shade. One was not supposed to run through there; Anax was, however, the first son of King Athanas, and so no one stopped him.

The bathhouse was crowded this particular early afternoon. It was early for the crowd to hit under normal circumstances, but Father's final audience with the Setessans was only an hour away. Everyone was expected to be there, both to be part of the display and to see what would happen.

Anax lingered in the tub, savoring the cool water on his skin. Before too long, the water felt cold, and he began to shiver. He climbed out and dried himself. His younger brother's voice came from behind him, with only barely concealed reproach. "So what did you do this morning?"

Anax turned to regard Timoteus. Anax was the elder by two years, but he had never been large, and his brother had never been small. Now they were the same size, although perhaps Timoteus's arms were a little bigger. Naked as they were, they were on display for everyone to see. No one made a show of looking, but there was no shortage of sideways glances from the men who would follow them into battle in half a decade.

"I finished Archaelos's *Effective Rhetoric* and ran eleven laps around the gymnasium," Anax said.

Timoteus snorted. "I threw the thirty-mina weight three feet farther than my previous best and did spear drills with a Lukos commander."



Art by Winona Nelson

Anax walked to the stool where his clothes were folded and began to dress. Timoteus turned to leave, but looked back over his shoulder. "When the Setessan army is bored of talking, is your plan to run away?"

A few men nearby stifled chuckles. Anax's face burned.

The Setessan ambassador entered the audience chamber with her entourage, wearing rich green linens. The chamber was filled to the brim with Akroan warriors lined up in formation. The ambassador approached the dais and bowed to Father with a flourish. "King Athanas, it is most unfortunate that we could not come to an accord."

Mother and Father stood tall and proud, their red cloaks trimmed with gold. Anax, Timoteus, and their sister Pelagia stood next to them. Father glared daggers at the ambassador. A few gray hairs had snuck into his beard. "You know my position. You are free to dispute it on the battlefield if you wish."

The envoy smiled mirthlessly. "The Setessan council is patient and our memory is long." She limply pointed an arm at Timoteus. "We may take this up with your heir."

Father put his right arm on Anax's shoulder and scowled. "This is Anax, my eldest."

The ambassador looked Anax up and down appraisingly, then frowned. "Your adherence to tradition is admirable, your majesty."

Father dropped his right arm to the hilt of his sword. "And you are a council of cowards. It is time for you to leave."

The ambassador bowed with a flourish and led her entourage out of the room without another word. Attendants closed the door behind them, and Father spoke. "I offered the Setessans what I thought was fair in return for the grievances they brought, and that was not enough. They will bring an army, or they will not." He drew his sword and raised it above his head. "But if they do, we will crush them."



Art by Peter Mohrbacher

The soldiers roared their approval.

"You are dismissed," he bellowed to the room, and the soldiers filed out. When they were gone, Father squatted and regarded his sons. He looked at the two of them together, as if he were seeing them for the first time. His eyes shone with pride as he looked at Timoteus. When he moved to Anax, his brow furrowed, and he did nothing to conceal his contempt.

Anax sat across from Georgios, the aging man who served as the personal tutor to King Athanas's children. His smile pulled at the wrinkles around his eyes and mouth. "Are you ready to begin?"

Anax nodded. "Thesis: Father doesn't like me."

Georgios jumped back in surprise. "What makes you say that?"

"He scowled at me today, and looked at my brother with pride. It happened in the open, and I'm sure many people were watching."

Georgios composed himself again. "Do you think it is truly you that he does not like?"

"I do not have another explanation."

The old man smiled. "Thesis: a king should value his realm's welfare above the individual preferences of himself or any of his subjects."

Anax thought. "That makes sense."

"Thesis: the most important decision a king makes is choosing his heir."

"Are the inheritance laws not clear?"

"Does the king have the authority to change laws?"

Anax's eyes went wide. "I'm going to the gymnasium."

Georgios gave him a disapproving look. "That is neither a thesis nor a question."

The student stood. "And I am the Prince of Akros. Thank you for the lesson, teacher Georgios."

Georgios pulled himself to his feet with a smile. "You're quite welcome."

The sun was already setting by the time Anax got to the gymnasium. He made his way to the sand pit, where the weights were. There was another boy in the pit as well; he was taller and stronger than Anax, and likely a few years older.



Art by David Palumbo

The other boy looked up at him with a slight smile, then at the setting sun. "A bit late to start working out, don't you think?"

Anax deflated for a moment, then fire began to burn in his belly. He drew himself up and walked toward the other boy with purpose.

Recognition and horror took over his face, and he recoiled. "Oh no. I'm sorry. Uh, hello there, I'm Zotikos. I haven't seen you use these before, but I could show you how."

Anax walked into the sand pit. "I would like that."

The older boy took one of the smaller weights in one hand and motioned for Anax to do the same. "Okay. Plant your feet at shoulder width. Hold the weight with both hands. Push out with your hips like this, and the weight should swing forward. Try to get it up to your chest, but without using your arms too much." He demonstrated a few repetitions, then stood. "That's about all you should do to start. You can throw them too, but you shouldn't do that until you're used to them."

Anax nodded. He hoisted the weight and tried to mimic the other boy's movements. After several repetitions, his shoulders, back, and hips were killing him.

Zotikos watched him struggle. "You should stop."

Anax dropped the weight and grunted. "I could keep going."

Zotikos nodded. "And then you would not be able to come back tomorrow. Stop and save your strength. You'll grow faster in the long run that way."

Anax nodded.

"One other thing. I often see you running around the track." Zotikos pointed at the pile of leather next to the weapon stands. "That's what the aprons over there are for. You put one on, put some rocks in the pocket, and go. A lot of kids don't like doing it because it's hell on your legs, but you seem to like running, so it might be good for you. It could give you a leg up on them." He chuckled at his own joke.

Anax nodded. "If you wouldn't mind, I would like to meet you here at about this time every day. I may start late, but I promise you I work hard." He flashed his best princely grin.

Zotikos considered for a moment too long, and gave a calculating smile. "I would be happy to."

The next day, Anax tried the aprons with the weights, just like Zotikos had said.

It made sense that the other boys didn't like it, because it was difficult. But he kept at it during his morning workouts, and it did make him stronger. He never got as far with the apron on, but the running itself was not the point anymore. The evening sessions with Zotikos continued too, although it quickly became clear that the older boy was quite a bit more skilled than Anax was.

One evening, Anax pressed him. "Why are you helping me?"

"You're the prince." Zotikos had not so much as blinked before answering.

Anax dropped his weight in the sand. "You don't have to, though, just like you don't have to come here every night. Why keep doing it?"

Zotikos sighed. "My father is a common foot soldier, and he has no ambition to rise higher. I train so I can surpass his station." He put his weight down and stretched. "And it seemed like you were looking for a friend."

Anax walked closer and put on his sternest face. "Am I a friend? Or am I just the prince?"

The older boy went down on one knee and stared at the sand. "I'm sorry, your highness..."

"Anax." The prince extended his hand, palm up. "Stand up." The older boy looked up and stood. "In the hallways of the palace, when I wear a laurel crown, then you may use my titles. But not here." He walked back toward the weight he had been using. "Here-" and he hefted it- "I am Anax."

Zotikos didn't say much for the rest of the evening. The next day, though, he talked quite a bit more.

In the following weeks, Anax expected the soreness and the increased strength. What he did not expect was that the other soldiers began to watch him and his brother with critical interest.

Anax sat across from Georgios in the small classroom. His legs were quite sore, but they felt good, and they were getting wider too. "Thesis: I'm getting stronger."

Georgios smiled and nodded. "Defend the claim."

"You believe it though!"

The older man gave him a sideways look. "I do, but this is a lesson about rhetoric. Convince me."

"I ran eleven laps on the sand track yesterday with four mina of rocks in my apron."



Art by Clint Cearley

Georgios nodded. "So you can run."

"I threw the thirty-mina weight a foot farther than my best."

He nodded again. "So you are stronger. How do you fight?"

Anax gave a mild pout. "That was not part of the claim."

Georgios chuckled. "Thesis: You will need to convince more people than just yourself that you are ready to rule Akros."

Anax sighed. "I grant your thesis. How do I do that?"

Georgios raised an eyebrow. "I don't know. If I were better at that sort of thing, I might have ended up in a higher position than the personal tutor to the king's children. But I do know that the Iroan Games will take place in four months, and that you will be expected to compete in at least one junior-division event."

"And my brother will too, no doubt." He slumped.

"He has begun training for the pankration, in fact."

Anax frowned. "The most impressive combat sport at the Games. Of course."

Georgios rolled his eyes. "Thesis: four months is a long time."

"That's indefensible! 'Long' is relative."

"Thesis: You understood my point." He glared at his student. "You could train for any event and be ready in time."

Anax shook his head, smiling slightly despite himself. "In Rhode's *The History of the Setessan Wars*, she speaks of the occasional wisdom of attacking the enemy boldly at his strength. If you win, you win utterly."

"If you lose, you also lose utterly."

"Thesis: I am already losing."

Zotikos scratched his head. "You would know that better than I, but this path is risky."

Anax smiled. "I have some ideas."

PART 2

Anax approached an estate near the edge of the Kolophon. There was a small gate and a small fence, and on either side of the gate were two great stones with the name "Sinon" carved into them.



The estate itself was of medium size; Sinon was not exactly noble, but he had been the defending champion of the pankration for three Games running, and outright victory there could bring a man no small measure of wealth.

As Anax entered the gates, a servant approached him and bowed. "Your Highness, how might someone as lowly as Sinon assist you?"

Anax looked calmly at the servant. "I only wish to speak with him."

"Of course, Your Highness." The servant scurried off.

He returned a couple of minutes later. "Follow me, please."

Anax followed him into a room where a man sat, a man who was tall sitting down. There was not a single strand of visible hair on his head or body, and tight cords of muscle rippled up and down his arms.

Anax sat down across from the man.

The man stared at Anax, his eyes giving nothing away. "Yes?"

"I would request the honor of training for the Games with you."

"Stand up." Anax glared at him but obeyed. Sinon looked him up and down, then stood and walked all the way around him. "You're fourteen?"

Anax turned his head to face the older man. "Fifteen, as of last month."

Sinon rolled his eyes. "Fifteen, sure. I only have time for one pupil. And you look quite a bit less promising than the one I'm already training."

"Excuse me?"

He turned his head toward the estate's courtyard. "Timoteus, I'll be right there!" Sinon looked back at Anax and shrugged. "Sorry."

"Sounds like that went poorly," said Zotikos. As usual, the gymnasium was nearly empty this evening, and only Anax was in earshot of the other boy.

Anax spread his legs, bent down on his right leg, and stretched his left hamstring. "Yes."

Zotikos made circles in the air with his arms. "You could always pick another sport."

Anax touched his toes for several seconds. "I already told Father I was going to do pankration."

"Oh." Zotikos's arms dropped to his sides. "Maybe I could help. Let's get everything out of the middle." They moved the weights to the side of the sand pit. "So how does this work?"

"We fight until someone goes unconscious or submits, but you can't bite or gouge out eyes."

Zotikos raised an eyebrow.

"Yes."

"And you're a little short," Zotikos said, "so striking doesn't seem like a great idea for you."

"I think I just threaten injury with joint locks until they submit. I can't imagine getting a knockout."

Zotikos scratched his head. "That sounds right."

Anax shrugged. "Want to try?"

Zotikos dropped into a back stance and his eyes went cold. Anax did the same. He crouched and tried to come in lower than Zotikos's center of gravity, but the other boy spun out of his grasp at the last possible moment, placing his hand on the back of Anax's neck. Zotikos shoved hard, and Anax tripped over Zotikos's planted foot and landed face first in the sand. The older boy dropped on top of Anax, grabbed his right arm, and pulled.

Anax's arm felt like it was about to pop out of its socket. "You win!"

Zotikos stopped the pressure. Anax rotated his shoulder, which still hurt. "How did you do that?"

Zotikos stood up. "I don't know. I just... did." He stood, furrowing his brow. "I guess that doesn't help."

Anax returned to his feet as well. "Not really."

Zotikos frowned. "I don't think I can help here."

Anax nodded. "I suppose not."

In the distance, the gymnasium door opened, and closed.

Zotikos looked over to where they had put the weights at the side of the sand pit. "So... more weight throwing?"

Anax shook his head. "I think I'm done for tonight. I'll see you again tomorrow."

Georgios was already in the classroom waiting for Anax when the prince arrived for his lesson the next day. "How did your errand go?"

Anax sighed as he sat down. "Sinon is already teaching my brother, and he won't take another pupil."

Georgios frowned. "That is unfortunate."

"Yes." Anax thought. "He might not have been the right teacher anyway, though. He was really big, and I'm not. Even if he won the last three games, someone smaller than him must have beaten him at some point."

"Do you know Kaletor? He is one of your Father's advisors."

"The older man with the twisted knee who walks with a crutch?"

Georgios nodded. "He competed in the pankration for several years. He was not a tall man even before his injury and might be willing to help. You will need to be careful with your approach, as he does not consider that a pleasant memory. He would not refuse a request to speak with you, although your father will not force him to help past that. I will speak with him on your behalf tonight."



"Thank you, Teacher."

The old man nodded. "Thesis: You are depending on me too much."

Anax sneered at him. "Going to the gym every night was my idea. I chose the pankration, not you. I can't know the history of every single man in the palace, but I told you exactly what I was looking for in a teacher. And," he said, "'too much' is hardly specific enough to defend."

The teacher nodded and smiled. "Very good!"

Kaletor's study was austere, little more than a cell with a table and two chairs. The man himself was just as severe, with a chiseled jaw and square head both covered in curly silver hair. Frown lines were worn deep into his face, and his swollen knee was just as gnarled as the twisted branch he used for a cane.

Kaletor regarded the prince from his seat with unguarded confusion. "Your teacher tells me that you wish to compete in the pankration four months from now."

Anax stood as tall as he was able. "I promised Father that I would, but honestly I don't know the first thing about how to do it well. I was wondering if you would be willing to help me."

"Four months is nowhere near enough for you to be a threat to win your division."



Anax shook his head. "I don't need to win the whole event. I just need to impress people." He thought. "And if I draw my brother, I definitely need to beat him."

Kaletor scratched his silver beard. "I can give you a chance at that, if you are willing to work."

"You should also know that Sinon is training my brother."

Fire flickered in the old man's eyes. "In that case, I will be honored to help you."

Anax smiled a hungry smile. "I train with one of my friends every evening at the gymnasium. Most people don't see us there, since we stay late. Would you be willing to come then?"

Kaletor reached for his cane. "I will be there."

Kaletor was true to his word, and began to teach Anax and Zotikos that very night. With his gnarled knee, he could not demonstrate techniques himself, but despite the injury he proved to be a capable teacher.

Kaletor's first lesson was that Anax should close immediately. An opponent shorter than Anax would also be weaker once Anax got him on the ground. An opponent taller than Anax would have a longer range before grappling began, and there was no reason to risk an early knockout from an unlucky strike to the head. It also saved training time, as they could focus exclusively on grappling.

Kaletor's second lesson was how to get the opponent on the ground. Anax was not as strong as the other boys his age-although he was beginning to catch up-and his best chance was to get them on the ground first, where technique could overcome raw strength.

After all that, Kaletor began to teach Anax all the ways to actually win a fight. There were holds that dislocated arms and legs, and ones that outright broke them. These, he said, were the easiest ways to win for the weaker combatant. There were many of these holds, and it took several nights to go through them all.

One night, Anax and Zotikos were practicing various locks. Anax went for an ankle lock, but Zotikos wriggled out of it, and Anax ended up with his friend's foot above his right shoulder instead. He felt Zotikos's knee reach the end of its extension, and started to push it even further.

"Stop!" They did, as Kaletor's voice had an unfamiliar note of fear to it. "That was highly dangerous!" He hobbled toward the two boys. "Anax, I'm impressed you found that, but you could have crippled him. If you push hard enough to force a submission from there, the other man won't walk normally again. Ever. You have to at least give them the chance to submit before that. Don't use that lock."

Anax stood and brushed sand off of his arms. "Is that what happened to you?"

Kaletor narrowed his eyes.

A few beads of sweat ran down Anax's face. "It was Sinon, wasn't it?"

Kaletor nodded.

"Would he teach my brother to do that?"

Kaletor's expression darkened. "It wouldn't surprise me."

"What would I do about it?"

Kaletor was lost in thought for a moment. "It has been a long time. Show me how you got there."

The boys showed him again, and he frowned. "Zotikos, there's a heel hook you can catch him in right there. Grab his heel, put your foot against his stomach, and twist just a tiny bit."

Zotikos did, and Anax yelped. "That hurts!"

"Don't push any harder. If you put anything on that-and I do mean anything-you'll break the ankle, and maybe do worse. It's nasty, but it'll work."

Anax smiled a little. "I'd like to try that."

"Anax," Kaletor said. The prince looked up at his teacher. "I showed you that because I trust you. Promise me you won't hurt anyone with it."

Anax nodded. "I need to win, not break people. I don't want to hurt anyone."

"Good. Now switch positions, and I'll show you, too."

Kaletor showed them both the heel hook that night, and many other things in the coming days. Slowly, painfully, Anax improved, and both teacher and student began to believe that Anax would be ready.

The stadium was packed to the brim for the junior division of the pankration, which was not the usual state of affairs. Normally, only the parents of competitors attended, but word must have spread throughout the Kolophon that the king's sons were competing. As it was, even the aisles were full of standing spectators.



Anax's first two bouts were easy. Both of his opponents were a few years younger than he was, and neither had much of a handle on how his body worked. After Kaletor's training, neither posed much of a challenge.

In the third round, however, Anax drew his brother. Timoteus had range, and therefore tried to start with strikes. His first jab was only a feint, too far out of range to be a serious threat. He stepped forward, and then threw a real punch. Anax could have blocked it and closed, but he flinched, and drew back instead.

Timoteus shifted his weight forward and threw a kick toward Anax's groin. This time, Anax was quick enough to dart inside the kick's range. He grabbed his brother's kicking thigh and opposite shoulder and shoved, and like that the two were on the ground.

Anax landed on top of him, but Timoteus recovered more quickly, and began to twist into position for an ankle lock—a safe move, one that would force Anax to submit but posed little threat of injury. Anax was a few inches away from position for a heel hook, but unless Timoteus overextended himself, there was no way for Anax to reach it.

Anax shifted his weight slightly, offering Timoteus the chance for a different lock—the kneebar that had crippled Kaletor. Timoteus went for it without a second thought. Anax was ready for him, though, and caught his brother's heel at the last possible moment. He twisted—just barely enough to make his point—and Timoteus froze and raised his index finger.

The crowd applauded as the two boys stood. Timoteus's face was a mask of rage as he turned away.

When the applause finally died down, Anax regarded his brother with contempt. "I'm disappointed," he said, loudly enough to carry but softly enough that it wouldn't seem like anything more than a private conversation.

Timoteus brushed sand off his shoulders as he turned back to face his brother. "What?"

Silence spread through the crowd. Many of the spectators craned their heads forward to hear. "You could have won safely, but I gave you the chance to cripple me the same way Sinon crippled Kaletor. And you took it. That let me reverse the hold." Shock appeared on many faces in the crowd. Anax put a mask of haughty disappointment onto his own. "And at the end, I could have ripped apart your ankle. You would never have walked again. But who would want to serve a king who crippled his own brother?" He took three steps away, and looked back over his shoulder. "I wouldn't."

Chatter exploded throughout the stadium. Anax left the ring without another word and prepared for the next bout, doing his best to ignore the crowd. He wanted very much to shout with triumph, or at least to smile. But that is not what a prince does, so he did not.

He lost his next bout to a tall young man who was about to come of age, and was stronger and more skilled. After the respectful looks that everyone gave Anax, though, he did not need a visit from Iroas to know that he had won.

Anax stood in the palace's private courtyard with his father, mother, and sister. Timoteus knelt alone in the center of the courtyard. Fifteen feet from him was a burly man holding a whip. The man drew the whip behind his head.

Crack.



A thin line of red appeared on Timoteus's back. The wound would heal, but he would bear its mark forever. Such was the cost of political crime in Akros.

Crack.

A second red line appeared. Blood from the first one began to drip. This punishment was a liberal interpretation of Akroan treason laws, but King Athanas was furious with his second son, and had insisted.

Crack.

A third line appeared. No one would ever forget that Timoteus had tried to cripple his future king.

Father turned to Anax, and the grim look on his face became a bit less stern. "We have begun the process of finding you a wife. We are considering a young woman named Cymede. She comes from a powerful family that we would do well to placate, but she is also beautiful. She will make you a fine queen."

Anax wanted very much to shout with triumph, or at least to smile. But that is not what a king does, so he did not.